SURFING IN INDIA

- **2004:** Mantra Surf Club, the country's first surfing school, comes up in Mulki, Karnataka
- **2011:** The same group that set up the school establishes Surfing Federation of India (SFI)
- **2016:** SFI organises first-ever Indian Open of Surfing at Sasihithlu beach in Mulki
- **2020:** Competition calendar gains consistency post COVID-19
- **2021:** Surfing makes Olympics debut in Tokyo
- **2025:** SFI is formally recognised by the Ministry of Youth Affairs & Sports, Government of India. Ramesh Budihal, from Kovalam, Kerala, puts Indian surfing on the map by becoming the first Indian to win a medal (bronze) at the Asian Surfing Championships in Mahabalipuram
- **2026:** Surfing to make its Asian Games debut in Japan. SFI picks Kishore Kumar, Sivaraj Babu, Kamali Moorthy and Sugar Shanthi Banarse for the squad



Harish P. and Nethra Arabolu running along Tannirbhavi Beach, Karnataka

Games as a reserve and, like many Indian surfers, comes from a fisherman's family. "It is like being one with nature." Goa's Sugar Shanthi Banarse, 21, who's in the women's team, says the sport helped her overcome her shyness and infused a lot of confidence. The curly-haired surfer, who runs a surf school in Ashwem, Goa, also loves the lifestyle that comes with the sport—travelling, exploring places and meeting people with a shared passion. "It is a big community. We share love and fun vibes," she says. "Once we enter the water, we are competitive. [But on the ground], it's hanging out, talking and training together."

CHOPPY SEAS AHEAD

But, as fun as surfing is, it remains an expensive pursuit. Most of the equipment is still imported and a majority of surfers in India begin their passion on borrowed or shared boards from surf schools, or they have shapers refurbish old boards. Owning a board remains a luxury, with boards priced upwards of Rs 55,000. What's not easy, either, is finding surfing spots that lend themselves well to riding the waves. "In surfing, we need exposure to different wave breaks," says Rammohan Paranjpe, vice president, Surfing Federation of India. "And it is not just about waves, it is about being in a competitive environment and rubbing shoulders with the best of the best and seeing what they are doing."

This is especially true of a sport like surfing, which isn't endemic to India. Moorthy's Tamil Nadu compatriot Kishore Kumar, 18, hailing from Covelong, won the men's category at this year's Indian Open of Surfing and is headed to the Asian Games. He dreams of being a professional surfer, someday competing in the World Surfing League and representing India at the Olympics. He is part of the first generation, alongside Moorthy and Budihal, travelling to training camps in Bali and Sri Lanka as well as competing in tournaments in Australia, Taiwan and the Maldives. "Talent is here, what we are doing is giving them exposure," says Paranjpe. "Earlier, we'd be blown away by Sri Lanka and the Maldives, which have better and more consistent waves than India. But today, we are beating them."

Banarse sees the Asian Games as a much-needed incentive for the women's scene to improve, too. Female competition is still small, the fear of injury, drowning and a tanned complexion often stops parents from letting their daughters take up the sport. "My mother faced a lot of resistance when I started surfing," says Moorthy. "Even my relatives didn't want me to surf. There were all these 'what if she' questions." But with the sight of her and Banarse fearlessly tackling the waves in Japan, Indian surfing could, just maybe, get its wow moment. Says Banarse, "It gives us a lot more exposure and opportunities. It's what girls need right now."

The loudest cheers at Tannirbhavi Beach this year, though, were reserved for local favourite Pradeep Pujar, 16, the first boy from Mulki to win the competition—bagging the under-18 category, he was the sole winner from the west coast at the Indian Open and ensured the lesser-represented region had something to cheer about over three days of competition. A protégé of the Aquatic Indica Surf School in Mulki, Pujar is a benefactor of the Surfing Swami Foundation and his parents work at the Mantra Surf Club. Perhaps he represents the humble beginnings of this sport in India, one indulged in not for glory or fame, but for the primal pleasure of being at one with the surf and the sea. ■